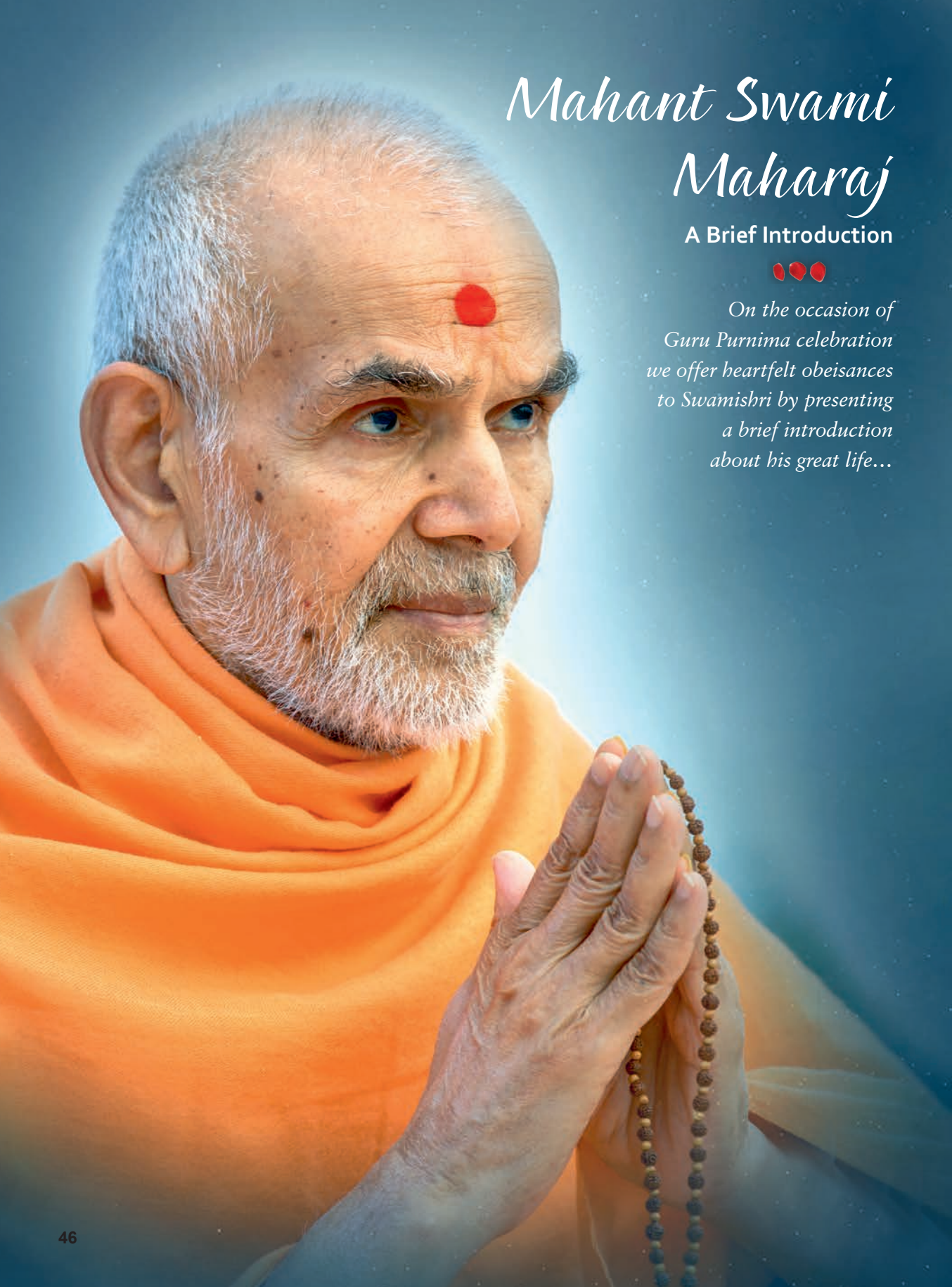


A portrait of an elderly man with a white beard and hair, wearing an orange shawl. He has a red tilak on his forehead and is holding a string of prayer beads (mala) in his hands, which are clasped in a prayer position. The background is a soft, blue gradient.

Mahant Swami Maharaj

A Brief Introduction



*On the occasion of
Guru Purnima celebration
we offer heartfelt obeisances
to Swamishri by presenting
a brief introduction
about his great life...*



BIRTH IN JABALPUR

On 13 September 1933, a spiritual star was born in Jabalpur, Madhya Pradesh, India. Manibhai and Dahiben Patel, originally from Anand, Gujarat, were blessed with a son, Vinubhai (Mahant Swami Maharaj). Manibhai was an ardent disciple of Shastriji Maharaj.

SHASTRIJI MAHARAJ'S BLESSINGS

In March 1934, Shastriji Maharaj came to Jabalpur and blessed the six-month-old Vinubhai and initiated him into the Fellowship. Shastriji Maharaj named him 'Keshav' and told Manibhai, "Your son will grow up to be a sadhu and render great service to the Sampradaya."



SCHOOL AND COLLEGE YEARS

Up to 1951, Vinubhai studied at Christ Church Boys' School in Jabalpur, completing 11th grade. He was quiet, thoughtful, ever-smiling and exceptionally brilliant. He was inclined towards reading good books. He studied with unwavering attention and interest in school, ranking either first or second in his class. Vinubhai possessed excellent and innate drawing skills. Football was his favourite sport.

* * *



In 1951, his parents returned to Anand. Here, he joined the V.P. Science College and enrolled to study BSc Agriculture at the Bansilal Amrutlal College of Agriculture in Anand. Though he could have chosen medical science or an engineering stream he decided to study agriculture so that he could often avail of Yogiji Maharaj's spiritual company and fulfil his aim of becoming a sadhu at the earliest.

LOVE FOR YOGIJI MAHARAJ

In spite of his father being a BAPS devotee, Vinubhai was not initially interested in Satsang. However, in 1951, during Yogiji Maharaj's stay in Anand, Vinubhai was touched by his saintliness and humility. He became attached to Yogiji Maharaj and rushed off to him whenever he got time from his college studies in Anand.



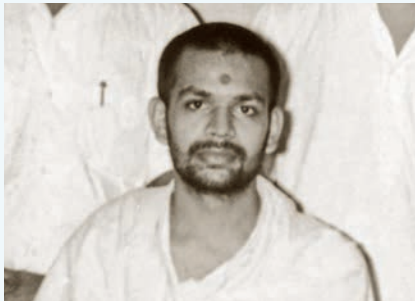


FIRST MEETING WITH PRAMUKH SWAMI

After Shastriji Maharaj passed away in 1951, Vinubhai went to Sarangpur and then to Gadhada for the murti-pratishtha ceremony. Here, 17-year-old Vinubhai first met Pramukh Swami, who was 29 years old. A lasting impression of him being a true sadhu, having a simple, straightforward and frank personality became forever etched in Vinubhai's mind. It was Pramukh Swami who first told him to become a sadhu. Yogiji Maharaj further consolidated the idea of becoming a sadhu and Vinubhai became determined to do so.

OPPOSITION FOR RENOUNCING HOME

As word spread among his relatives that Vinubhai desired to become a sadhu, there was stiff opposition. His mother and other relatives were strongly against him becoming a sadhu. But Vinubhai's determination and the guru's blessings eventually convinced all to permit him to renounce home.



PARSHAD DIKSHA AFTER COMPLETING COLLEGE

In 1956, as soon as Vinubhai graduated with a BSc in Agriculture, he rushed to Yogiji Maharaj in Gondal. He served him as a youth for one year. Yogiji Maharaj showered his affection and started mentoring him in *brahmavidya*. He engaged him in various menial *seva*, often told him to observe waterless fasts and to listen to spiritual discourses.

On 2 February 1957, Gondal, Yogiji Maharaj gave Vinubhai the *parshad diksha* and named him Vinu Bhagat.

YOGIJI MAHARAJ'S BLESSED SEVAK

Thereafter, Yogiji Maharaj kept Vinu Bhagat in his service for three-and-a-half years (1957–1960). He served by washing utensils, attending to correspondences and other *seva*. Yogiji Maharaj moulded the young disciple for his future responsibility as the spiritual head of the BAPS Santha.

In 1959–60, Yogiji Maharaj and Pramukh Swami took Vinu Bhagat with them on a satsang tour of Africa.



HISTORIC SAFFRON DIKSHA

In May 1961, Yogiji Maharaj gave the *bhagwati diksha* to 51 educated youths during the ceremonial installation of *kalashes* on top of the *shikharas* of Gadhada mandir.

When Yogiji Maharaj gave the first *diksha* to Vinu Bhagat he ecstatically raised his hand and named him Keshavjivandas Swami. The event is of great significance in BAPS history.



AS MAHANT SWAMI

In 1962, Yogiji Maharaj consecrated a *hari* mandir in Dadar, Mumbai. At the guru's behest the 51 newly initiated swamis stayed in Akshar Bhuvan, Dadar, to study Sanskrit and do *seva*. Yogiji Maharaj appointed Keshavjivandas Swami as the head of all the swamis and from thenceforth he addressed him as 'Mahant Swami'.

DEVOTION TO BHAGWAN AND GURU

Mahant Swami inspired the swamis in Dadar mandir with bhakti, *seva*, *katha*, kirtan, *vairagya*, fasting and other spiritual sadhanas. His personal bhakti towards Bhagwan and guru Yogiji Maharaj was unique. He made decorative flower garlands for Thakorji and Yogiji Maharaj, offered and sang *thals*, made ornate *hindolas* to devoutly rock Thakorji and meticulously arranged *annakut* before Thakorji. In addition, he never tired of doing the daily *seva* of washing dishes and large cooking pots.



SATSANG IN MUMBAI

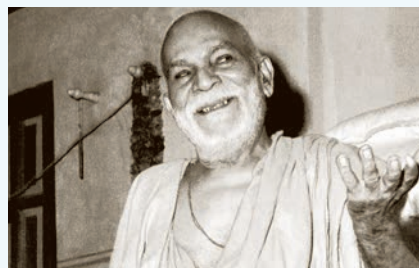
During his stay in Dadar mandir, Mahant Swami also discoursed to the devotees, solved their woes and sanctified their homes. His profound and spiritually enlightening discourses infused faith and joy in the lives of the swamis and devotees of Mumbai. All eagerly awaited to hear him and to be blessed by him.

Mahant Swami also travelled to the villages of Gujarat and Maharashtra to nourish and inspire satsang.

YOGIJI MAHARAJ REVEALS MAHANT SWAMI'S GLORY

On many occasions, Yogiji Maharaj spoke profusely about the glory and greatness of Pramukh Swami and Mahant Swami:

- Pramukh Swami is the greatest among all. He is the head of all. By obeying his instructions you will progress. Also, follow whatever Mahant Swami says. He will resolve your distress.
- If you worship God and abide by the instructions of Pramukh Swami and Mahant Swami you will become like gold.
- If you wish to go to Akshardham you will require a stamp [visa]. When Mahant Swami gives you the stamp, then nothing up to Prakruti Purush can obstruct you.
- Our Mahant Swami's spiritual state is like that of Bhagatji Maharaj. He will not take to mind whether anyone respects him or insults him.





PRAMUKH SWAMI MAHARAJ BECOMES THE SPIRITUAL SUCCESSOR

On 23 January 1971, Yogiji Maharaj passed away. The entire Satsang community was plunged into deep grief and sadness. Prior to his departure, Yogiji Maharaj declared, “After me, Pramukh Swami is present. Pramukh Swami is my all.”

Mahant Swami says, “Yogiji Maharaj showered such love that I was naturally drawn and attached to him. But, Pramukh Swami gradually made such an impact, that soon I became attached to him. Ultimately, they are both one. It was only the outer form that had changed.

“The things that drew me to Yogi Bapa I saw in Pramukh Swami Maharaj as well. There was no hypocrisy in Yogiji Maharaj and none in Pramukh Swami Maharaj either. There was an innate simplicity in his life. In all his work, he was totally natural. He had many other virtues. These became evident over

time and I developed affection for him like I had for Yogi Bapa.”

After Yogiji Maharaj’s earthly departure, Mahant Swami continued his services under the wings of Pramukh Swami Maharaj.



IN PRAMUKH SWAMI MAHARAJ’S SERVICE

In 1977, Mahant Swami travelled on an overseas satsang tour with Pramukh Swami Maharaj. After returning to Mumbai, he left Mumbai to start *vicharan* (travelling) to satsang centres throughout India.

In 1979, Pramukh Swami Maharaj appointed him as the leader of the Swaminarayan Akshardham project for Gandhinagar. Mahant Swami also offered his services during the mega festivals held in Gujarat, UK and USA. He gave inspiring speeches during *shibirs* to children, youth and *karyakars* in India and abroad. Sometimes, regardless of his poor health and difficulties during *vicharan*, he travelled extensively in Satsang to please the devotees. He also performed the foundation stone-laying ceremonies and *murti-pratishtha* rituals of mandirs.



HIGHER RESPONSIBILITIES OF THE SATSANG FELLOWSHIP

With Pramukh Swami Maharaj’s advancing age and ailments Mahant Swami’s *vicharan* and satsang responsibilities increased.

In Ahmedabad, on Wednesday, 6 March 2013, Pramukh Swami Maharaj wrote a letter to the BAPS Satsang community, “You are all aware that for some time now my health has not remained well and so I have been unable to meet everyone in person. Therefore, from now on, all sadhus and devotees

should meet Pujya Mahant Swami for guidance on their personal matters and questions to obtain solutions.”

Mahant Swami’s humility, saintliness and profound discourses are a hallmark of his life, and devotees and well-wishers became impressed with his darshan and experienced inner peace.



PRAMUKH SWAMI MAHARAJ'S EARTHLY DEPARTURE

In Sarangpur, on Saturday, 13 August 2016, Pramukh Swami Maharaj left his physical body to depart to Akshardham. The entire Satsang community was plunged into grief at Swamishri's departure. For four days countless devotees and well-wishers came to Sarangpur to pay their last respects to Swamishri.

On Wednesday, 17 August, Mahant Swami Maharaj performed the last rites by igniting the funeral pyre.

On Sunday, 14 August, Pujya Dr Swami announced that four years previously, on Friday, 20 July 2012, Pramukh Swami Maharaj had written a letter that Pujya Mahant Swami would succeed him as the guru and president of the BAPS. The letter said, "I appoint with happiness and joy, and in my fullest conscious state, Pujya Mahant Swami, Sadhu Keshvajivandas (Guru Jnanjivandas), as the president of BAPS, that is, as guru, after my physical departure."

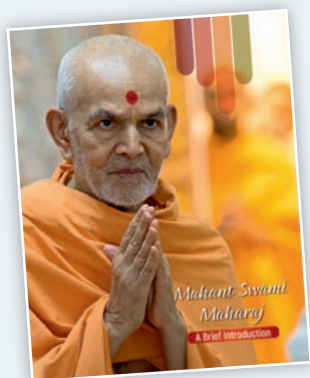
Pramukh Swami Maharaj had often spoken about Mahant Swami's spiritual virtues and greatness. In 1968, in Mumbai, Pramukh Swami Maharaj had praised, "Doing darshan of Param Pujya Mahant Swami fills one with profound tranquillity. Everyone is captivated by his saintliness and humility, and he has always given me his fullest support."

In 1966, in Atladara, while remembering Mahant Swami Maharaj's father, Manibhai Naranbhai Patel, Pramukh Swami Maharaj said, "He has gifted us a great gem. That great gem is Mahant Swami! That is the greatest of all gifts; Mahant Swami is such that his darshan bestows peace. He has been blessed immensely by Yogi Maharaj."

TIRELESS VICHARAN

After becoming the guru at 83 years of age, Mahant Swami Maharaj's *vicharan* and activities have increased manifold. He has travelled on satsang tours to Africa, UK and North America in 2017, the Asia-Pacific in 2018, and the UAE and Africa in 2019.

His tireless *vicharan in India*, meeting devotees and well-wishers, responding to their letters, attending to the flurry of daily phone calls and performing the foundation stone-laying and *murti-pratishtha* ceremonies of new mandirs and overseeing many other activities provide spiritual and moral nourishment to countless. In addition, Mahant Swami Maharaj has given impetus to BAPS social services in India and abroad. He does all this with calmness, humility, love and devotion. ♦



Mahant Swami Maharaj

A Brief Introduction

- ♦ His Early Years ♦ With Yogiji Maharaj
- ♦ With Pramukh Swami Maharaj ♦ As the Guru...



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